of the Palestinian Refugee Problem by Benny Morris) began for the first time to present an alternative view. These books proposed that while the military victory of the IDF in 1948 was no doubt remarkable, it was accompanied by a political failure to see that denying Palestinian Arabs a homeland would create a new problem that was destined to impact Israel for decades to come.

In the Arab world, the war of 1948 was understandably seen as a disaster. By any rational analysis, the combined forces of four powerful Arab nations should have been capable of defeating the new State of Israel. That this failed was seen partly as the outcome of different agendas pursued by the Arab participants in this war, each with its own territorial ambitions and each often operating independently of the others. Before the war began, the defeat of Israel seems to have been taken for granted, and each of the Arab participants focused not on winning the war but on staking its claim to hegemony in a post-war Palestine. This point of view certainly has merit, though of course it is not possible to be sure that even if the Arab armies had operated with closer cooperation, they would have won the 1948 war.

The most plaintive and unchanging narrative of the war comes from Palestinian historians. There is no doubt that the Arab people in Mandatory Palestine had as much right to the lands on which they lived as did the Jewish settlers in the same region. While Israel consolidated and grew after the war, and the other Arab nations involved endured, there would be no creation of a Palestinian nation. That single failure would leave a legacy of hatred and dissatisfaction that echoes to the present day. Millions of Palestinians still live as stateless people in other nations or in enclaves in the West Bank and the Gaza Strip.

By winning the 1948 war, Israel ensured its survival. But it did so at the cost of creating a refugee crisis that continues to afflict Israel and the whole Middle East more than 70 years after the end of the war. At the same time, had Arab Palestinian leaders accepted the proposed UN partition in 1947 or at least been willing to negotiate, there might well have been an independent Palestine today. If anything can be learned from the 1948 Arab-Israeli War, it's that wars are won on the battlefield, but lasting peace comes only from agreements that take account of the rights and needs of everyone involved.